350.ORG US AUDIENCE GROWTH: SKILLS TEST

PREPARED BY: DALLAS DIAZ (THEY/THEM) | ASSIGNMENT: SKILLS TEST, US AUDIENCE GROWTH POST ANALYZED: "US INFLATION HITS 3.7%" (INSTAGRAM, 350ORG)

Overview of My Thinking

As you probably remember from our conversation, I can and will be a bit long winded, so this doc is a bit long. **Sources** for the data and research I used to ground my conclusions and interventions are linked at the bottom of the doc. My suggestions for adjusting this post include recommendations for the content type, content copy, post copy and strategy considerations for playing to Instagram's (evil) algorithm. Sometimes being a digital content manager/social media strategist means you what you gotta do 🤷🏾

This post as it stands, was built for people who already follow 350, so the metrics show that it did not have much reach with new users . Followers made up 88.1% of views and 95.8% of interactions. Instagram ranks posts on watch time and sends, and prioritizes video content and Reels. Static images and carousels that are not designed to indicate to the viewer that they should scroll through are on the out list. The copy on the content is a bit too much all at once. Dense copy on social media that we know is going onto a platform that most users interact with via mobile device needs to breathe. I say that to mean, that our brains have a harder time processing or knowing where to start when reading on our phones. An animation or better-yet, a person speaking to the camera would do wonders here. Much more below:

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1. What the numbers say

The screenshot tells a clear story once you break it down.

- **Repeat exposure, not new reach.** The post drew 3,332 views from 1,537 unique viewers, about 2.2 views per person. Feed reshows to the same people inflate view counts without growing the audience.
- **Followers engaged about three times more per view.** Followers account for roughly 2,935 views and 68 interactions, about 2.3% per view. Non-followers account for roughly 396 views and 3 interactions, about 0.8%.
- **Almost no profile discovery.** Only 101 views came from the profile. The 676 views labeled "From Other" are the only sign of discovery beyond the home feed.
- **The snapshot is slightly stale.** The screenshot shows 45 likes, while the live post shows 52. The analytics were pulled before the later likes arrived.
- **Shares need checking.** The screenshot appears to show four shares. Shares carry posts to new people, so I'd confirm that number before citing it.

2. The Attention Economy

While it's something I personally hate, if we are going to use platforms that rely on the attention economy, we have to play into it.The post's format and framing both work against how Instagram distributes content. Instagram pushes content to the algorithm based on how long users engage with it. Watch time, likes per reach, and sends per reach as are the main ranking metrics. Instagram now ranks on total watch time plus replay rate. Sends between users have been noted as the goal creators should optimize for.This is the attention economy at work. Platforms earn from advertising, and advertising earns from time spent on the app. Content that holds people longer, gets rewatched, and gets sent to friends is what the system rewards. If we want 350's message to reach anyone outside the existing base, our content has to win that competition.

The format data backs this up:

- **Reels reach more people.** Socialinsider data puts Reels at an average reach rate around 30.8%, roughly double carousels (about 14.5%) and more than double static images (about 13.1%).
- **Single images are losing ground.** Metricool's 2026 study found that for single-image posts, reach fell 21.96%, interactions fell 25.41%, and the engagement rate fell 45.98% compared with the same period a year earlier.
- **Carousels still earn saves.** Carousels get about 9x more saves than single-image posts. They have a role as a companion format, but they don't replace Reels for reach.

3. Why it Underperformed

1. **The audience was wrong for a growth goal.** The post reinforced people who already agree with 350.
2. **The format gave the algorithm nothing to measure.** A static image has no watch time, replay rate, or completion, so Instagram has little to rank.
3. **The angle didn't reach US viewers.** The campaign's strongest argument is that the February closure of the Strait of Hormuz pushed oil past $100 a barrel. The post never

connects that to American gas prices. Gasoline (all types) rose 34.2% over the year, and that is the number that would have made the post land.

4. **There was no ask.** The campaign calls for a windfall tax on oil profits and an end to fossil fuel subsidies. The post never states either, so readers had nothing to do.
5. **The language was campaign vocabulary.** "Fossilflation" and "corporate greed" won't resonate with a US reader who has never seen the campaign. Strategy on how to manage this is in the Section below.
6. **Some voices were missing.** The post talks about "citizens" and "households" in general. It doesn't speak to renters, rural drivers, or lower-income families, who usually carry the heaviest fuel costs. Those are the people this message should be built around.
7. **There's a brand and rights risk.** The image centers a Shell station and credits an AFP photo. We should check the license before reusing agency images, and consider whether naming one company is the strongest framing.

4. Do this - Content "Runway" & Thought Leadership:

One post won't move a growth number. The good news is that you could build a series from this content:

"What your fill-up costs"

Integrated Content Strategy: Each video and carousel references another post within the content series. Initially, posts are paired. We can look at metrics later down the runway to make some decisions about adjustments and testing. What's coming into my brain is considering if we would want to try a test to drive engagement to lower performing posts by highlighting again by tying it to a format or topic that we see is performing better. More in [Growing and Glowing - Grounding in Metrics and Making Opportunities to Learn]

Lead with a Reel. Reels should be the primary format, built to hold attention from the first second. Use video and animation: a person speaking to camera, a pump display, kinetic text, a

simple animated map of the Strait of Hormuz. Keep it around 30 seconds and loop the ending back into the opening so viewers watch again.

Use an adjusted carousel as the companion. Once the Reel does the attention work, a carousel can carry the sourced detail for anyone who wants to save it. It's the saving format, not the reach format.

Rules:

- Videos
    - Every video opens with the same hook pattern "Your cost at the gas pump, gas, fill is up [this amount]. Here's why and what you can do." The hook must always make the viewer ***immediately*** hear and think "Oh that is happening to me and I want to jump into the comment section and see what other people are saying about what these people are saying." Repeating the structure lets the audience learn what to expect, while the content types vary.
    - First 15 second MUST include pop cultural reference, or screenshot of article from tweet or article
    - Insert one image or animated version of corresponding IG post; reference this post as a place where viewers can get a more in-depth breakdown on what the video covers. . More on this in **Growing and Glowing - Grounding in Metrics and Making Opportunities to Learn**
    - End with call to action, add variety:
        - Comment Below
        - Specific campaign CTA
        - Check out this partner org
        - Engage with us "this" way to stay posted.
- Carousels
    - Every carousel MUST be designed with elements to prompt the users to scroll through the full post
    - Each Carousel order follows a general format

        - Embedded cut of corresponding video

- Time is a Social Construct, Make It What You Want
    - Just had to write that to make sure that you read this strategy lol. Back to the algorithm and attention economy point, do not let it work against you. If we are going to think of this as a series, we need to act like TV script writers. Where in the series do we put the information that we want to have the biggest impact? In the middle, that way we already have a relationship with an audience this content has built, and enough content to keep pushing and making adjustments to what our most important point brings in.

Format logic:

- **Reels carry reach.** Every week includes at least one Reel, and the early weeks lean on video to reach non-followers.
- **Carousels carry saves and sources.** They pair with a Reel when the Reel introduces something complex, or stand alone when the content is a sourced explainer.
- **Paired posts reference each other.** The Reel points to the carousel for sources, and the carousel points back to the Reel for the story.
- **Single-format posts test one idea at a time.** They show which formats hold up for this audience before we commit more production time to them. I would test this as its own series, however, "definition slides" ready to use as padding within our content calendar terms such as “Fossilflation”. My idea is to use a character known as the "Jargon Giraffe" so we can have a host for this content series who can allow us to produce animations and stills alike. I’m not hurt if you tell me is idea is corny.

Post	Theme	Format	Hook	Content Intention

1	The headline number: why gas is up 34%	Reel (30 sec) + carousel	"Gas is up 34% in a year. Here's why."	Introducing the series. The carousel holds the sources.
2	The Strait of Hormuz timeline	Reel only (animated)	"What the Straight of Hormuz Gotta DO With You."	Standalone mechanism explainer
3	Who pays: the commuter's cost	Reel only (creator story)	"What is your fill-up actually costing you?"	Standalone, built on a real story. Ask the Audince A question.
4	Who's collecting the extra	Reel (creator story)+ Animations, Carousel	"Who's collecting the extra?"	Sourced explainer, built for saves, given the most of our creative capacity. These kinds of posts tend to garner the most interactive engagement so , content with real people and NAMING who is accountable should be posted in the middle of the series and be as so we build enough of a report with an audience who shares our content before we drop our most important pieces.
5	Your monthly gas bill in one number	Reel + carousel	"Your monthly gas bill went up by [X]. Let's do the math."	Reel points to the Post 1 carousel for sources. The carousel shows the calculation.
6	What solar changes for a household	Reel with a partner or locale advocate story	"Uplift and tie partner perspective/campaign to our work"	Partner post to reach non-followers

7	This is not just just a problem because of the war	Carousel only	Is this just a war problem? It's about dependence.	Sourced argument for saves and shares
8	What you can do: the ask	Reel + carousel	"Here's what to ask your representative."	Recaps the series. Reel points to Posts 4 and 7 for the facts.
POSTED AS PADDING OR IF EXTENSION TIME IS NEEDED FOR SERIES CONTENT	Glossary + Jargon Breakdown	Animated Posts +Carousels	Hosted by the "Jargon Girraffe" What is "Fossilflation" anyway?	As the kids say, "That's a big word for Elmo." "Fossilflation" for example. Let's not assume everyone knows what we are talking about. I insist that we have some fun by assuming the opposite and use it as an opportunity for audience growth, content type testing, and building thought leadership. ***Create a sub-content series!*** Make it consistent with an identifiable host character that viewers associate with this part of the series, animated character rather than a staff member who would have to devote more on the camera work for this piece.

Why this cadence?

- **Weeks 1 and 2 lean on Reels** to get the series in front of people outside the existing base.
- **Weeks 3 and 4 add more carousels** to convert viewers into savers and sharers.
- **The partner post in Week 3** brings in a different audience, which is the non-follower reach the original post never got.
- **The paired posts (1, 5, 8)** give the algorithm two chances to surface the same theme, and give viewers a reason to swipe through to the sources.

Reel script: "Why is your gas so expensive?" (30 seconds)

Format: Vertical 9:16, captions on, one speaker at a gas pump. Film a person who has agreed to appear, or use a clip we have rights to. Don't use the AFP photo.

Time	Visual	Voiceover / on-screen text
0:00–0:03	Close-up of a pump display, then the speaker turns to camera	**"Gas is up 34% in a year. Here's why."**
0:03–0:08	Speaker at the pump, showing the current price	"Today, a fill-up here costs [insert local price]. Let's talk about why."
0:08–0:14	Graphic: "CPI 3.7% in September, up from 3.4% in August"	"Inflation hit 3.7% in September. Gas drove more than half of that monthly jump."
0:14–0:20	Graphic: "Gasoline +9.1% in one month," with an animated map of the Strait of Hormuz	"Gas jumped 9.1% in a single month. When the Strait of Hormuz closed in February, oil went past $100 a barrel."
0:20–0:25	Speaker, tighter framing, looking at camera	"Who pays? You do. Commuters, delivery drivers, rural families. Price spikes hit your budget first."

0:25–0:30	End card: "Tax oil windfall profits. Use it to lower your bills."	"Tell your state representative to tax windfall oil profits and cut fossil subsidies. Link in bio." On screen: **"What did your last fill-up cost? Tell us below."**

Carousel companion (6 slides)

1. **Hook:** "Gas is up 34% in a year. Here's why."
2. **The number:** Inflation at 3.7% in September, gasoline up 9.1% in a month.
3. **Why now:** The Strait of Hormuz closure, with the source named on the slide.
4. **Who pays:** A short example of a commuter, delivery driver, or rural family. Insert a local average gas price from AAA or EIA.
5. **The fix:** The campaign's ask in plain language.
6. **The call to action:** Contact a state representative, plus the comment prompt "What did your last fill-up cost you?"

Caption (draft)

Gas is up 34% in a year. Inflation hit 3.7% in September, and gasoline did more than half of that jump. Households are paying the bill while oil companies keep their windfall. What did your last fill-up cost you? Tell us below, and contact your representative to ask for a windfall tax on oil profits. #GreatPowerShift

Production notes

- Insert the local average gas price from AAA or EIA on the day we film, and cite the source on screen.
- Check any claim about oil company profits against a US source before posting. The campaign page relies on global figures that we must translate to a US audience.

4. Growing and Glowing – Grounding in Metrics and Making Opportunities to Learn

- **Learn what works and implement it quickly.** Once we are at a point where we can say X content performed better than Y, but both did far better than G, try content G again and find a way to thread it directly to what worked.

  "Yall really loved 'this' but I want to make sure that you get the picture that directly connects to 'that' and you can do something about it today."

- **Non-follower share of views.** The original post was about 12%. A target of 30% or higher would show real reach beyond the base.

- **Watch time and replay rate on the Reel.** These are the signals Instagram ranks on.

- **Sends and saves.** Sends carry content to new audiences, and saves show the carousel is doing its job.

- **Hook test.** Post two openings and compare the first three seconds of watch time.

- **What does our audience actually want to do?** Offer different CTAs, Test what works, just ask the audience what actions we can help them learn about.

5. Other things to consider

- **Staying Ahead of Instagram's Algorithmic Preferences.** Put short, Instagram just wants everything TikTok has. Every Social Media platform that makes money from advertising does. It also rewards "early adapters" a.k.a creators who use new platform features in ways that generate engagement first. When Instagram launched Reels, it was a TikTok-like short video feature, with videos of up to 15 seconds and tools for editing, audio, and effects. The launch was explicitly framed as a response to TikTok. I personally had to ask my fiancee to get on TikTok because her showing me funny trends on her IG that I had seen months ago on TikToc got exhausting quickly. Watch

TikTok, plan for Instagram.

- **The copying goes beyond one feature.** Instagram Stories was modeled on Snapchat, and Reels followed the same pattern. Reporting from 2022 noted that the company was considering turning all Instagram videos into Reels, which shows how far the platform was willing to go to match short-form retention. I bet it will not be long before IG allows creators to launch actual episodic content like TikTok does.

What this means for strategy:

- **Expect the format to keep shifting.** Platforms copy what keeps people watching, so specific features will keep changing. We should build a repeatable system around hooks, pacing, and clear calls to action, not around one trend.
- **Plan for the platform's incentives.** The ranking rewards time spent, and time spent supports ad revenue. That's a reasonable reading of how the system is built, though it describes incentives, not any one platform's stated intent.
- **Hold a line on a mission.** Optimizing purely for watch time can pull a campaign toward entertainment at the expense of substance. For 350, the Reel should earn attention and then give viewers a concrete next step.

Sources

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